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Students Experiencing Low Self-esteem or Low Perceptions of Competence

APA Mental Health Primers



Teachers are an important part of establishing and maintaining healthy environments for children to learn and grow. Teachers can help students who are less confident in themselves, or who are afraid to make a mistake, to build their feelings of self-compassion and competence. Teachers can also play an important role in referring students to

Disclaimer

This information is designed to help teachers respond to students who may be in need of support. It is not intended to be used as a diagnostic tool or to replace the use of formal assessments employed by mental health professionals. Additionally, it

professionals in the building who can be of assistance.

is important to consider the context of the situation, individual differences, and cultural and linguistic factors.

Audio series: Students experiencing low self-esteem or low perceptions of competence

Join Amanda Dettmer, PhD, research scientist at the Yale School of Medicine's Child Study Center, as she speaks with Wendy Grolnick, PhD, professor of psychology at Clark University, who shares some of her expertise on students experiencing low self-esteem or low perceptions of confidence.

0:00 / 18:25

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What is self-esteem?

Self-esteem is the degree to which students feel satisfied with themselves and feel valuable and worthy of respect.

Perceived competence is a belief that one has skills in a particular area (e.g., math, spelling, peer relationships). Self-esteem and perceived competence are necessary for students to take risks in their learning and to bounce back after failure or adversity. Low self-esteem or lack of confidence leaves students doubting their ability to succeed, making them hesitant to engage in learning or take appropriate academic growth risks. Self-esteem is often built and buttressed through estimable acts and achievements—even small ones.

How might low self-esteem be expressed by students in school?

Students may make self-disparaging comments such as, "I'm stupid," "I can't do this," "I always do everything wrong," "No one likes me," etc.

Students with low self-esteem may take blame for things that are not their fault or are out of their control, or they may try to control other children's behavior to alleviate a sense of helplessness.

Students may react to adversity by giving up, avoiding risks, or disengaging from tasks, or turning off their cameras during virtual learning (VL).

Students may be reluctant to try new things or be unable to tolerate typical levels of frustration. They also may pretend they don't care, may clown around, or may be aggressive to cover up their lack of confidence, or log off from the virtual learning environment (VLE) abruptly.

Students may do very well for a period of time, then suddenly underperform.

Students may be afraid their success was a fluke or be worried that expectations from others are suddenly too high.

What can teachers do?

Do: Give specific and genuine positive feedback on effort rather than outcome, when warranted. For example, "You made a lot of progress on that project in just an hour," or, "The topic sentence of that paragraph is really strong."

Don't praise excessively or vaguely or provide generic praise like, "Good job."

Do: Point out concrete signs of progress, even if they are small.

Don't give repeated, general pep talks that include, "You can do it!"

Do: Showcase accomplishments by displaying students' work in class or calling parents to tell them how proud you are of the students' efforts.

Don't focus solely on suboptimal behaviors or performance.

Do: Engage students in a conversation about their interests, and point out students' skills privately.

Don't address the behavior publicly or assume a student is just like other students.

Do: Engage the students' interests by setting them up for success: give them specific tasks at which they will excel, such as caring for the class pet or running things to the front office. In a VLE, this may look like choosing music for the virtual classroom, posting a math question on the discussion board, or reflecting on their strengths on a particular assignment with a peer in a breakout.

Don't ignore or avoid the students or the issues they're facing or assume they aren't up to a task.

Do: Be mindful of ensuring equity in terms of acknowledging and providing positive feedback to all students.

Don't continually affirm certain/the same students or compare achievements between students.

Do: Remember that students transitioning from the classroom to VLE, or vice versa, may experience different levels of success depending on the environment.

Don't base feedback upon historical achievements, expectations, or successes; the transition between learning environments impacts many students.

When to act

- If the student continues to exhibit a significant shift in behavior occurring over several weeks, or the frequency or severity increases, seek extra support from administration or school mental health professionals.
- If the student displays similar patterns of behavior with other subject teachers.
- If you have concerns about the student engaging in self-harming behaviors.

Refer students to further help if needed

- Be sure to follow relevant school and district policies regarding students experiencing inattention and distractibility in school.
- Contact school counselors, psychologists, social workers, and other mental health or relevant personnel.

Resources

- [American Psychological Association Topics \(/topics\)](#)
- [Using Praise to Enhance Student Resilience and Learning Outcomes \(/education-career/k12/using-praise\)](#)
- [Maximizing children's resilience \(/monitor/2017/09/cover-resilience\)](#)
- [Building Self-Esteem ↗](https://psychcentral.com/lib/building-self-esteem/)
(<https://psychcentral.com/lib/building-self-esteem/>)
- [Being Me: A Kid's Guide to Boosting Confidence and Self-Esteem \(/pubs/magination/441B057\)](#)
- [I Want Your Moo: A Story for Children About Self-Esteem, Second Edition \(/pubs/magination/441B036\)](#)
- [Institute of Education Sciences Research-Based Strategies for Effective Remote Learning ↗](https://ies.ed.gov/use-work/resource-library/resource/training-)
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Empirical research

- Beghetto, R. A. (2007). Factors associated with middle and secondary students' perceived science competence. *Journal of Research in Science Teaching: The Official Journal of the National Association for Research in Science Teaching*, 44(6), 800-814.
- Guay, F., Boggiano, A.K., & Vallerand, R.J. (2001). Autonomy support, intrinsic motivation, and perceived competence: Conceptual and empirical linkages. *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*, 27, 643-650.
- Kamins, M. & Dweck, C.S. (1999). Person vs. process praise and criticism: Implications for contingent self-worth and coping. *Developmental Psychology*, 35, 835-847.
- Pesu, L., Viljaranta, J., & Aunola, K. (2016). The role of parents' and teachers' beliefs in children's self-concept development. *Journal of Applied Developmental Psychology*, 44, 63-71.
- Zentall, S. R., & Morris, B. J. (2010). "Good job, you're so smart": The effects of inconsistency of praise type on young children's motivation. *Journal of Experimental Psychology*, 107(2), 155-163.

Related Mental Health Primers

Students experiencing stress

(/ed/schools/)

Teachers play an important role in guiding students suffering from excessive stress to other professionals who can assist

Students experiencing sadness

(/ed/schools/)

Teachers can assist students experiencing sadness by providing emotional support, promoting positive peer relationships, and connecting students with

Students experiencing bullying

(/ed/schools/)

Teachers are critical contributors to promoting safe school interactions and promoting positive relationships

other school
professionals

The Mental Health Primers are developed by the [Coalition for Psychology in Schools and Education \(/ed/schools/coalition\)](#). This resource was updated in October 2021 with support from cooperative agreement NU87PS004366 funded by the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC). Its contents are solely the responsibility of the authors and do not necessarily represent the official views or endorsement of the CDC or the Department of Health and Human Services.

MENTAL HEALTH PRIMERS

These primers by the Coalition for Psychology in Schools and Education help teachers identify behaviors in the classroom that are symptomatic of mental health and other psychological issues.

APA contributes to psychological science by producing cutting-edge applied research to inform educational practices and policies, translating it into accessible formats for educators, championing evidence-based approaches, and supporting policies in which educators and students thrive.

[Learn more about applying psychological science in pre-K to 12 schools and education \(/ed/schools\)](#)

APA PRE-K TO 12 RESOURCES

- [Top 20 Principles for Pre-K to 12 Education \(/ed/schools/teaching-learning/top-twenty\)](#)
- [Teaching and Learning Evidence-based Resources \(/ed/schools/teaching-learning\)](#)
- [APA Pre-K to 12 Education Advocacy \(https://www.apaservices.org/advocacy/ec\)](#)



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